



Figure 1: YALI's partitioner in action—notice the help window on the right

that matters here—because YALI is seriously quite good, someone opined.

It's the usual chore of triggering your BIOS to boot from the CD/DVD ROM, placing the CD (yeah, don't forget to burn the Pardus ISO image available in the DVD to an empty disk; I just noticed that the other distro reviewers this month totally missed this point of providing the complete picture about stuff that matters :)) in the drive, and hit the reset button of the computer tower. (*Dude, it's called a cabinet.* Oh, shut it!)

And thus, the journey began! First looks are impressive—the colour scheme of a yellow-orange shade, I've got to say, is very good. *Wait a sec now... Good gawd! What's with this foreign language on the boot screen?* Turns out it's Turkish, by default. Thankfully, there's an F2 button on my keyboard and I could switch to English. *Yes, that's much better now!*

Then press the F3 button to select the video mode as well. Since my CRT monitor supports up to 1280 x 1024px, I decided to give that a try. The default option to boot Pardus seemed good enough to me, so I hit *Enter*. The nice and plain splash screen with a progress bar that basically hides the verbose kernel boot messages was soon replaced by the installer's welcome screen with the licence message. It's GPL. *phew!* Obviously, they needn't ask me if I'm okay with it or not, but good that they have put a button there if anyone wants to read the GPL—it's good information for some folks. The addition of a *Release Notes* button is a bonus, and I'd say has been implemented at the right place. Not to forget the *Show Help* button as well—upon clicking it, a nice help box on the right shows up with information on what to expect (Figure 1). Nice add-on for the ones in need of help, as they can leave this on throughout :-). Anyway, overall, it's a very well-thought layout for a welcome screen.

Next up is the CD integrity check screen. *Useless!* Then the keyboard layout—English is good. Then comes the time zone—no world map here, so scroll down in search of 'Asia/Kolkata'. Then the screen to create the system

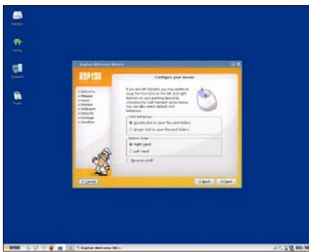


Figure 2: The Kaptan guides you after first boot

(I mean ordinary) users—you can create multiple users, give them admin privileges, and set it to auto login, if you like. Set the root password and host name in the next one, following which the partitioner pops up.

OK, it lists both my hard drives, and there's no way I want to go with an automatic partitioning scheme, so I chose the time-tested manual option. The following screen lists both the hard drives as tabs, and presents a horizontal bar as the partition (Figure 1). This is where you'll select the chunk which says 'free space' (or a pre-partitioned space that you can format), move the slider to set the size, click the drop-down menu to set the 'use' criteria—root, home, swap, etc.—and hit *Apply*. The labels for 'use' cases are interestingly titled 'Pardus System Files' for the root FS, 'User Files' for the home partition, 'Swap Space', and 'Storage Area' for God knows what (if you happen to figure it out, do let me know because I'm too lazy to test it). I figure these labels would make more sense to new GNU/Linux users, although they might confuse a veteran. Nonetheless, the partitioner seems very intuitive, and looks much more useful compared to the partitioners available even with some of the major distros.

Next up are the bootloader options, followed by a final summary screen listing the details of all the selections you've made in the installer. Interestingly, YALI is yet to make any changes to your system; so this is your final chance to go back and make amends if you suddenly notice you've done something stupid during the previous steps. If you're satisfied, you can hit—well, *Next* is now greyed out, so—*Begin Install*.

Following this, YALI will partition/format the disk, and proceed with the installation of packages. Yes, you're right—there's no package selection option; everything will be installed by default. The installer is not the fastest I've seen—took around 20 minutes on my Athlon X2 5800+ system with 2gigs of RAM, and around 30 on my Celeron laptop with 512 megs of RAM. But the information on the installer presents a case for lots of software, so if you're